

5 Habits You Must Quit to Get Lean

Channel: Brandon Carter · Published: Sep 12, 2026 · Watch: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=B5BN_7eUclI Source: full transcript

Executive Summary

Brandon Carter, a 27-year veteran trainer, identifies five specific habits quietly canceling out otherwise solid fitness efforts — and gives blunt, actionable replacements. The core message: most people don't need a new diet or workout, they need to stop doing these five things.

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Habit 1: Treating Weekends Like a Free-for-All 1:33

- The classic pattern: Monday–Friday the person is locked in — prepping meals, tracking calories, hitting 10,000 steps, drinking water, no alcohol
 - By Thursday they feel like "a budget David Goggins"
 - Friday weigh-in shows 1–2 lbs of progress — proof it's working
- Then Friday at ~6:47 PM a text comes in: "Yo, what you doing tonight?"
 - Dinner out, drinks, appetizers — and the deadly mindset shift kicks in
- **"I deserve this" is one of the most dangerous phrases in the English language**
 - Brandon calls these "mediocre mantras": *I deserve this. One won't hurt. One day won't hurt.*
 - Nobody ever says "I've been good all week, let me order some tilapia" — it's always the opposite
- Saturday: brunch with French toast covered in syrup ("fancy children's food") and three mimosas at 11:30 AM
 - Saturday night: go out again
 - Sunday: hungover → Uber Eats → eating crazy
 - Monday weigh-in: up 3 lbs — "you hustling backwards"
- The bank account analogy:
 - Mon–Fri: 500-calorie deficit per day = **2,500 calorie deficit saved up**
 - Saturday "walks into the bank with a ski mask" — brunch, dinners, drinks, desserts, late-night snacks wipe it all out
 - Sunday is "driving the getaway car"
- Core truth: "Your body doesn't know what the f*** a weekend is. Your fat cells don't have Google Calendar."
 - Every day is identical to your metabolism — all 7 days count equally
- Brandon's position on cheat days:
 - Not a fan of cheat *days*; a cheat *meal* can work for some people
 - He personally hasn't had a cheat meal in **~4 years**
 - "Some of y'all are just way too good at cheating" — able to erase 6 days of dieting in one weekend
- Cheat meals induce cravings — the hidden cost people miss:
 - Cheat foods spike dopamine and are scientifically engineered to taste delicious
 - After a cheat day, cravings for those foods persist Monday, Tuesday, sometimes into Wednesday
 - The clean food you're supposed to eat tastes *worse* by contrast
 - This cycle resets every week when the next cheat day happens

- Brandon: once he stopped cheat meals entirely, cravings disappeared — "I don't even think about it" when cake is in front of him
- Fix: **Think in weeks, not days.** Track what happens across the full 7-day window. "A lot of people don't have a diet problem, they have a Saturday and Sunday problem."
 - If you must have a cheat meal, keep it to a single meal — don't treat it like a challenge or a 24-hour event

Habit 2: Drinking Your Calories 9:34

- Common scenario: someone says "I barely ate anything" but is consuming high-calorie drinks without registering them as food
 - Coffee with sugar, cream, and caramel syrup = "a liquid candy bar"
 - Smoothies with peanut butter, oat milk, protein powder, and berries = "you put the whole grocery store in the blender" — that's groceries, not a drink
- **Fruit juice is a scam:**
 - Juicing removes the fiber (the best part) and leaves only sugar + vitamins
 - Nutritionally equivalent to drinking Kool-Aid and taking a multivitamin
 - "Even though it's natural sugar, your body processes it the exact same way" — it's still calories
- Sports drinks are another trap:
 - Example: guy does 27 minutes on the treadmill, burns ~180 calories, then immediately drinks a sports drink with **240 calories**
 - Net result: he got fatter from the workout session
- Why liquid calories are especially dangerous:
 - You can drink 400 calories and barely notice it
 - Eating 400 calories of lean protein and vegetables would be difficult and filling
 - When calories are a limited resource on a diet, every calorie should be "working for you" — primarily as satiating protein in real meals, not a 480-calorie caramel macchiato
- Fix: Drink mostly water and zero-calorie drinks. Brandon personally drinks diet soda daily and has for decades (been drinking it since age ~16, now nearly 44, full-body MRIs and bloodwork are perfect, hasn't been sick in 11 years)
 - If scared of artificial sweeteners, just drink water — the non-negotiable point is: **don't drink your calories**

Habit 3: Not Tracking Your Calories 13:57

- "If you're not tracking, you're slacking."
- Everyone believes they naturally know how much they're eating — they don't
 - Intuitive eating advice from a 20-year-old Instagram model doesn't apply to a full-grown adult who's been trying to lose the same 15 lbs "since the Obama administration"
- What people forget even when they remember their meals:
 - Remember the eggs → forget the butter
 - Remember the salad → forget the dressing
 - Remember the steak → forget the hollandaise sauce
 - Remember dinner → forget the three handfuls of almonds eaten throughout the day
 - Forget all the small snacks grazed on at home or at the office
- Peanut butter is a prime example of a calorie-dense food people chronically underestimate
 - "Nobody accidentally eats 600 calories of broccoli" — but peanut butter? People scoop it without measuring and consume a massive calorie load
- **Healthy ≠ low calorie** — a critical and commonly missed distinction:
 - Avocados are healthy. Nuts are healthy. Olive oil is healthy. You can get fat eating all three.
 - "Your body doesn't issue a caloric refund because the food was organic."
 - California friends who eat all organic, take vitamins, eat mushrooms — still fat because they eat too much of it
- Brandon's track record: has tracked every meal for **15 years straight**, including before MyFitnessPal existed (used notebooks)

- 27 years as a trainer — every single time a new client starts tracking for the first time, they are *shocked* at how many calories they were actually eating
- The accounting analogy:
 - You know your bank balance, rent, mortgage, car payment — you notice when Netflix raises its price by \$2
 - But with calories: "I eat good. I eat healthy." — That's like running a business without tracking expenses: you go broke

Once you know what you're actually eating, fat loss becomes dramatically easier — tracking is the single biggest unlock.

- **Brandon's specific prescription (given to thousands of clients with "extreme success"):**

- Calories per day = **bodyweight in pounds × 10** (current bodyweight, NOT goal bodyweight)
 - Example: 200 lb person → 2,000 calories/day
- Protein = **1 gram per pound of bodyweight** (again, current bodyweight)
 - Example: 200 lb person → 200g protein/day
 - Even 300 lbs → 300g protein (Brandon himself gets 250–300g/day at ~195 lbs)
- Why a steep deficit rather than the commonly recommended 200–500 calorie deficit:
 - A 200-calorie deficit is dangerously easy to accidentally erase
 - Example: a sauce he weighed for his skinless chicken thighs was **200 calories** by itself — one condiment can wipe a small deficit
- Why high protein is a built-in cheat code — the **thermogenic effect of food**:

Macronutrient	Calories burned during digestion
Fat	0–3%
Carbohydrates	5–15%
Protein	20–30%

- Consuming 100 calories of protein → body only absorbs 70–80 calories net
- Protein burns 2–3× more calories to digest than any other macronutrient
- A protein-dominant diet means you're automatically in a deeper deficit than your logged numbers suggest
- Protein also keeps you fuller (more satiating), further reducing overconsumption

Habit 4: Keeping Junk Food in Your House 24:46

- "Some of you are deliberately putting yourself in a position where failure is the default response."
 - If you eat a bag of chips every night and wake up angry about it — just stop buying the chips
- Brandon's own example: his favorite cheat food was Häagen-Dazs ice cream — "I could eat the whole thing in a second"
 - Solution: there is no Häagen-Dazs in his house. He doesn't need discipline to resist it because it's not there.
- **"Discipline is for amateurs"** — the real goal is to design your environment so making the right decision is the *default* response
 - Relying on discipline = setting yourself up for failure regardless of willpower
 - The dangerous myth: discipline means putting temptation in front of yourself and repeatedly defeating it — "Why? What exactly are you training for?"
 - If junk food is in the house, you have to say no to it every single day, sometimes multiple times a day
 - At the grocery store, you only have to say no once — "I'd rather use my discipline once in the grocery store than be fighting for my life at 11 PM in front of the pantry"
- The concept of **friction** — more powerful than discipline:
 - Amazon makes Subscribe & Save effortless (low friction) → you buy more
 - Canceling a subscription requires navigating multiple menus, tiny hidden buttons (high friction) → you don't cancel
 - Apply this deliberately to your own habits:
 - Decrease friction for behaviors you want (house full of prepped healthy meals, food that fits your caloric goals ready in the fridge)

- Increase friction for behaviors you don't want (don't buy junk; if you want ice cream, you now have to get your keys, put on pants, drive somewhere, park, go in — at some point you'll think "I don't want it that bad")
- You can also reverse-engineer the environment positively:
 - Prep meals in advance
 - Stock the fridge with foods that fit your caloric targets
 - Make good decisions *convenient* and bad decisions *annoying*
- "Your environment should make getting lean easy, not turn everything into a psychological experiment."

Habit 5: Not Moving Enough Outside the Gym 30:19

- The typical sedentary day even for someone who "works out":
 - Walk 15 feet to computer → sit 8 hours → drive to gym → lift 1 hour + 20 min cardio → drive home → sit on couch → Netflix → sleep
 - "You end up living like a human house plant"
- People massively underestimate **NEAT** (non-exercise activity thermogenesis) — calories burned from standing, walking, taking stairs, running errands, cleaning
- Traditional cardio is overrated for fat loss:
 - Running 1 mile burns only ~100 calories — less than a banana or a handful of almonds
 - It's called *cardio* because it benefits your cardiovascular system, not because it efficiently burns fat
 - High-intensity cardio (sprints, HIIT) is hard on joints, taxes the central nervous system, and hurts gym performance
- **The cheat code: 20,000 steps per day**
 - Everyone Brandon has coached who hit this target got into the best shape of their life
 - Burns **800–1,000 extra calories per day** — a massive number you'd never match with traditional cardio without serious recovery cost
 - Walking requires zero recovery — won't affect your lifts, won't stress your joints, won't tax your CNS
- How to fit 20,000 steps into a normal schedule:
 - Morning: 30-minute walk (no running required)
 - Lunch break: 30 minutes eating + 30 minutes walking
 - After work: 60-minute walk (make it social — bring family, friends, start a walk club) → ~6,000 additional steps
 - During the workday: every hour, walk for 10 minutes
 - Combined, this hits 20,000 steps/day
- Response to "that's unrealistic":
 - "Just say *you* can't do it. Don't say nobody can do it."
 - "If you argue for your own limitations, you get to keep them."
 - If you truly can't hit 20,000 — do what you can. "Don't let what you can't do stop you from doing what you can do."
- Closing mindset reframe: most people have spent their whole life "trying to see how much they can get away with instead of how far they can push themselves" — that's how they got fat
- **Action summary from the video:**
 - Stop treating weekends as diet vacations
 - Stop drinking calories
 - Start tracking calories and macros (bodyweight × 10 for calories; 1g protein per lb bodyweight)
 - Remove all junk food from your home; engineer your environment for success
 - Walk more — aim for 20,000 steps/day to burn an extra 800–1,000 calories daily